

SECTION 3

Setting Team Norms

7

Dear Manager, You're Holding Too Many Meetings

by Benjamin Laker, Vijay Pereira, Ashish Malik, and Lebene Soga

Meetings serve different purposes, ranging from informal social gatherings to formal strategy discussions. They often show up on our calendars as recurring events (with no end date in sight). New research shows that about 70% of all meetings keep employees from working and completing all their tasks. While there was a 20% decrease in the average length of meetings during the Covid-19 pandemic, the number of meetings attended by a worker on average rose by 13.5%.¹ Ineffective meetings that waste our time can negatively impact psychological, physical, and mental well-being.²

Our recent research found that newly promoted managers may be contributing to the problem. New managers hold almost a third (29%) more meetings than their seasoned counterparts.³ When we set out to understand the hidden costs of flexible working practices, we discovered that meetings have steadily increased in frequency and duration since companies transitioned to the remote workplace.

There are a couple of reasons this might be the case. Without the ability to connect with their team members in person as often, people newly promoted into management roles may feel extra pressure to build connections digitally. And they may be driven by a desire to be more visible and get buy-in from their teams. It's also easier than ever to stack our days with back-to-back meetings. When we're working remotely, we don't have to travel between private meeting rooms. We can pretty much leave one meeting and log into another a minute later.

What's the impact? Our research shows that 92% of employees consider meetings costly and unproductive.⁴ And countless online interactions can lead to "Zoom fatigue"—a condition neuropsychologists say is a big contributor to "technostress."⁵ In short, more meetings don't help *anyone* reach their goals.

To investigate further, and consider the implications for managers, we surveyed 76 companies that reduced the number of meetings over the course of 14 months. We found that although building trust and achieving cohesion rely on the frequency and quality of a team's interactions, meetings are no longer the best way for managers to accomplish those things. In fact, there are much more effective ways to develop bonds in the absence of face-to-face meetings—including having *fewer* meetings altogether.

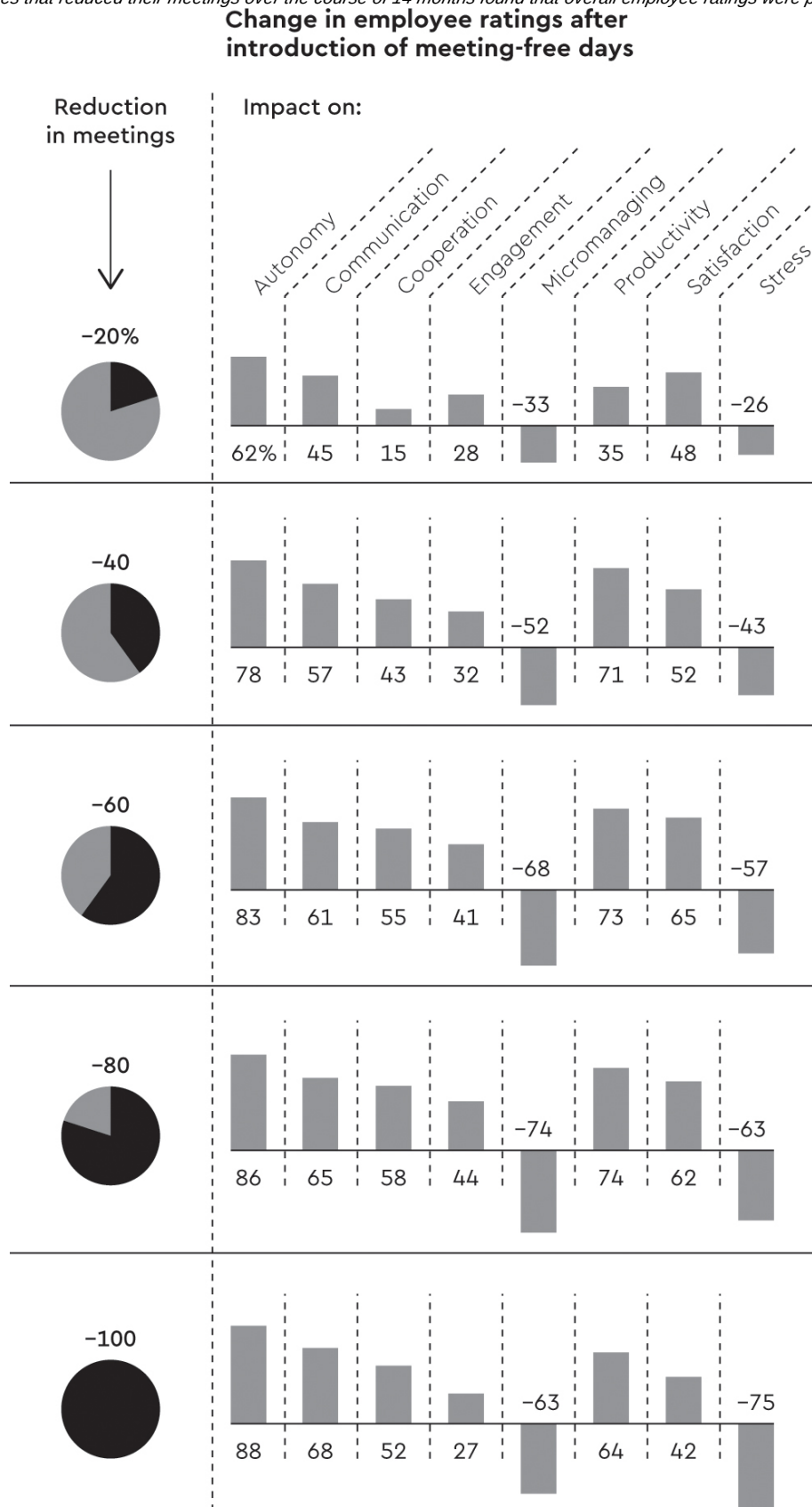
The Benefits of Having Fewer Meetings

Across the 76 companies we surveyed, we found that employee productivity was 71% higher when meetings were reduced by 40%. This is largely because employees felt more empowered and autonomous. Rather than a schedule being the boss, they owned their to-do lists and held themselves accountable, which consequently increased their satisfaction by 52%. (See [figure 7-1.](#))

FIGURE 7-1

Impact of fewer meetings

A survey of 76 companies that reduced their meetings over the course of 14 months found that overall employee ratings were positively impacted.



Removing 60% of meetings increased cooperation by 55%. Workers found better ways to connect one-on-one at a pace suitable for them, often using project management tools, such as Slack or Teams, to aid communications specific to each project. In doing so, the risk of stress decreased by 57%, which improved employees' overall well-being.

When meetings declined by 80%, we found that employees' perception that they were being micromanaged lessened by 74%. People felt valued, trusted, and more engaged, subsequently working harder for their company. Communication was 65% clearer and substantially more effective. The reason is that there were far fewer misunderstandings. To review an assignment or request, people would quickly check a previous Slack conversation or a project outline. The often-used phrases "I thought you told me ..." or "I was under the impression ..." were rarely used.

How to Scale Back Meetings

If you're a manager trying to establish healthy and impactful team norms, we have some advice to help you rethink your approach. By following our suggestions, nearly half of the companies we investigated reduced meetings by 40% over a three-month period. Thirty-five percent achieved three no-meeting days per week, and 11% achieved four.

Be very selective

Think about the meetings you've conducted or participated in recently. Which ones have been the most useful? You're probably thinking about a new project launch or a brainstorm that required a two-way dialogue in real time. As a general rule of thumb, we recommend holding meetings only when absolutely necessary. That typically includes:

- To review work that's occurred (what worked or didn't and why)
- To clarify and validate something (policies, team goals, and so on)
- To distribute work appropriately among your team

Even in those cases, you should carefully edit your invite list. Is *everyone* really needed? Or can you make the meeting optional for some people? The less important the topic is to their work, the less engaged your team members will be.

Encourage your team to flag or cancel meetings if they aren't the best use of their time. Make it clear that, as their manager, you encourage it and won't judge or punish them. Being judicious about which meetings add value and which don't will help free up people's calendars. Doing so also forces managers to rethink the informal ad hoc engagements that pepper everybody's calendars.

Interestingly, we found this strategy garners loyalty toward managers. Granting autonomy allows people to job craft, which previous studies show helps them find meaning in their work.⁶

Transition your daily status meetings to Slack or Teams

Daily huddles are the most frequently held meetings, and often, they are the most difficult to give up. As a new manager, you may feel that it's important for your team members to be aware of one another's work in order to reach your goals as a group. These meetings may seem like the best time to do this.

We have another suggestion: Set up a Slack or Teams channel specifically for this purpose. Every weekday, schedule a message to go out at 9:00 a.m.: "@here What's on your plate today?"

Ask your team members to respond within the hour, explaining what they're working on, any important project updates, setbacks, and so on. Managers (and your team members) can then scan the responses and follow up privately on updates that may need more context.

Our research found that 83% of employees preferred using these chat touch points over traditional one-to-one meetings because it saved them time. If your team members have a question, they can drop you a message instead of having to find a 30-minute block on your calendar.

Make the Most of Your One-on-One Meetings

by Steven G. Rogelberg

The best managers recognize that one-on-ones, or regular meetings with your direct reports, are not an add-on to their role—they are foundational to it. Those who fully embrace these meetings as the place where leadership happens can make their teams' day-to-day output better and more efficient, build trust and psychological safety, and improve employees' experiences, motivation, and engagement.

But how can you prepare for and facilitate effective one-on-ones?

Create an Agenda Before the Meeting

Both direct reports and managers should contribute to the agenda of a one-on-one so that both your priorities, and your employee's concerns, can be addressed. Collaborating on an agenda can be as simple as having each party create a list of topics to discuss.

Alternatively, some managers create the agenda from broad questions, such as: What would you like to talk about today? How are things going with you and your team? What are your current priorities, and are there any problems or concerns you would like to talk through? Is there anything I can help you with or anywhere I can better support you? What do I need to know about or understand from your perspective?

But don't focus too much on immediate tactical issues and fires to be put out. Periodically weave in longer-horizon topics such as career planning and developmental opportunities—by either taking five or 10 minutes at every meeting to discuss those areas or dedicating one out of every three or four meetings to addressing them.

Listen More Than You Talk

Once you've prepared for a meeting, a fruitful discussion will depend on your ability to create a setting in which your employee feels comfortable. A valuable one-on-one addresses both the practical needs and the personal needs—to feel respected, heard, valued, trusted, and included—of the employee.

Make sure to actively listen as your direct report speaks. Display genuine interest without judgment and acknowledge the employee's viewpoint even if you disagree with it. Ask questions that clarify and constructively challenge that viewpoint. Encourage your team member to provide thoughts on the matters at hand and potential solutions to problems. Stay vigilant about your body language and reactions to ensure that you're creating a welcoming and safe space.

Improve Your Meetings Over Time

Ideally, both parties should leave the conversation feeling valued, respected, and well-informed, with clarity about next steps on projects, solutions to problems, and the commitments that each of them has made. However, the most important metric for success is whether your employee found the meeting both valuable tactically and fulfilling personally.

To learn where you stand and to improve these meetings over time, start by asking your team members for feedback and ideas to make future one-on-ones better. Or you can anonymously survey your team with three basic questions: What's going well with the one-on-ones? What's not going well? Do you have ideas for improving them?

Excerpted from "Make the Most of Your One-on-One Meetings," *Harvard Business Review*, November–December 2022 (product #R2206L).

Use digital tools for asynchronous work

The next time you have a brainstorming meeting, ask, *Can some of this be done asynchronously?* The answer is probably yes.

For example, tools like Mural and Google Forms can be used to get people to submit their ideas in advance. Then you can schedule a follow-up meeting to review them together, likely cutting your meeting time in half. Eighty-three percent of employees in our survey preferred this approach over traditional methods, claiming it helps them contribute on their own time and further refine ideas in person.

Additionally, meeting-dependent activities like checking in on the progress of projects can be tracked asynchronously on a dashboard in a way that is transparent to everyone. This approach, we found, can help prune calendars, leaving more space for valuable “no meeting” time and focused work.

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Whereas our data highlights the importance of holding fewer meetings, we want to emphasize that managers need to understand what works for their unique contexts to maximize the full benefits of these strategies. For example, we found that the advantages of no-meeting periods begin to plateau after reducing meetings by 60% and actually wane beyond that. Satisfaction, productivity, engagement, and cooperation all decline when meetings are reduced completely, instead of retaining at least one day for meetings. We posit that when two days per week are retained for meetings, it can prove beneficial.

Even so, with the traditional meetings yielding little return on time investment, the opportunity cost is too high not to act now. Your teams are full of talented and capable people doing what they do best, but they need space to do so. By better understanding how they want to work together, how meetings fit into that, and where meetings do and don’t add value, you’ll minimize the need for useless meetings.

QUICK RECAP

If you’re a manager trying to establish healthy and impactful team norms, start by rethinking your approach to meetings.

- **Be selective when scheduling meetings.** Don’t schedule one unless you need to review work that’s occurred, clarify something significant, or distribute work.
 - **Transition your daily status meetings to Slack or Teams.** Use chat touch points instead of traditional one-to-one meetings to save time.
 - **Use digital tools for asynchronous work.** Allow team members to contribute to discussions on their own time by using online tools like Mural and Google Forms. Then, further refine ideas in person.
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Adapted from content posted on hbr.org, March 9, 2022.

Wondering how to make hybrid meetings work for you and your team? Watch this video:



8

Don't Let Poor Communication Slow Down Your Team

by Gleb Tsipursky

As more and more employees are working remotely or in hybrid work environments, the need for effective communication has become even stronger.

In a recent report by FlexOS, employees rated their managers a mediocre seven out of 10—the equivalent of a C, if graded—on effectively managing hybrid and remote teams. Worse, 30% said they're frustrated by unclear communication from their bosses.¹ Some of these challenges certainly come from the more siloed communication environment created by remote and hybrid work.

As a manager, it's your job to establish communication norms for your team. When managers are unclear in their communication, it can rob teams of their focus, diluting the overall quality of their output. Managers need to realize that clear, consistent communication isn't optional; it's imperative. Poor communication impedes both individual and collective progress.

So how can you become an excellent communicator in this ever-changing work environment?

Set Expectations Up Front

One of the challenges that can come with communicating remotely is information overload. We're all constantly getting bombarded with emails, Slack messages, phone calls, and the like. Align with your team on the optimal use of these various communication platforms. For example, while email may be suited for formal correspondence and long-term directives, instant messaging apps like Microsoft Teams or Slack can handle immediate needs and quick clarifications.

Being aligned as a team on which tool to use and when can significantly reduce communication friction. Consistently stick to the standards you set and remind others if they slip up.

Consider Creating a "Clarity Canvas"

When starting a new project together as a team, create a set of documents that succinctly outlines project goals, individual responsibilities, process instructions, and key deadlines. This centralized hub, which I call a "clarity canvas," affords seamless access to the same reservoir of information and can serve as a touchstone for everyone, averting confusion and minimizing back-and-forths.

Create these documents together—convene all team members, either in person or virtually, and work through each one to ensure you're all on the same page. Through this alignment, not only are comprehension gaps addressed in real time during the canvas-creation phase, but you also lay a robust foundation for process adherence and knowledge dissemination.

Make Everything Accessible

Making sure every team member—remote or in-office—can easily access all communications is nonnegotiable. Keep meticulous records of decisions made, meeting minutes, and project statuses in a centralized digital location accessible to all.

Set standards for where documents are stored and how information is saved. If your organization has access to multiple cloud storage platforms, set rules for what gets uploaded and where. It can also be helpful to provide guidelines for sharing settings to make sure everyone who may need to access the information can find it easily.

Establish Office Hours

One way to facilitate direct communication with your employees is by setting aside official office hours every week—both remotely and in person. This is time when you should be readily accessible via chat, phone, or video call to discuss any concerns or questions. Consider it a virtual open door, so that both in-office and remote employees have equal opportunity for one-on-ones. There's no need for a specific agenda during this period; just focus on listening empathetically to your staff and addressing their needs. Be fully present. This will make it easier to foster connections with your direct reports.

Do Regular Debriefs

After important company announcements, it can be valuable to set up debrief meetings with your team. Doing so will help you evaluate how well your people understand and accept the announcements and will give you the opportunity to clarify and address any questions. Remember, your team is looking to you to assess how to respond to top-level announcements. You are the mediator of the C-suite's messages to your team.

Bring Everyone Together

A team that plays together stays together. Organizing monthly team-building activities can forge stronger bonds and create a more cohesive team culture. While in-person activities often yield higher emotional engagement, virtual events can also be effective, especially for entirely remote teams.² Incorporating these organized interactions serves as a catalyst for open communication by breaking down hierarchical or interpersonal barriers and nurturing an environment where ideas can flow freely among team members. This fosters a culture of transparency and trust, which are foundational for effective communication within a team.

Check In Periodically

It's not wise to assume that no news is good news. One way to check in with your team is to conduct anonymous surveys every month to gauge what activities are resonating with them. Here are some sample questions tailored to gauge the resonance of activities, measure the effectiveness of implemented plans, and nurture an open communication culture:

- Which aspects of the recent communication and collaboration activities did you find most beneficial? Please explain.
- Is there any communication or collaboration activity that you feel didn't resonate well with you? What suggestions do you have for improvements?
- What steps can we take to improve the openness and effectiveness of communication and collaboration within our team?

- Have the recent changes in [specific process or activity] helped in improving your work experience? Please provide examples.
- On a scale of one to 10, how would you rate the effectiveness of the team's communication and collaboration?

Follow this up with a team discussion to interpret the survey results, aiming to balance varied preferences. Once the plan is in motion, don't forget to measure its effectiveness and encourage feedback. Fine-tune the approach each quarter, keeping it ever-responsive to the team's evolving needs. The ensuing discussions from these check-ins and feedback loops can not only give team members a platform to articulate their preferences and concerns, but also foster a culture of open communication. This procedural transparency in addressing and iterating on the team's needs and preferences demonstrates a proactive communication culture, indispensable for nurturing a resilient and adaptive team.

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Communication is not just a soft skill; it's the linchpin of effective management. As you go through this process, don't shy away from leveraging new technologies that can bring your team closer together, both emotionally and operationally. As a new manager, you have the opportunity to reset old ways and establish a more effective role as a communicator in this hybrid and remote landscape.

QUICK RECAP

Clear communication isn't optional; it's imperative. Here are a few tips on improving communication norms with your team:

- Align with your team on the optimal use of the various communication platforms (email, messaging, video calling).
 - When starting a new project, create a set of documents that outlines project goals, responsibilities, instructions, and key deadlines.
 - Set standards for where documents are stored and how information is saved.
 - Establish virtual and in-person office hours for one-on-one discussions.
 - After important company announcements, debrief with your team to address any questions.
 - Bring everyone together for team-building activities on a regular basis.
 - Conduct anonymous surveys every month to measure the effectiveness of your approach.
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Adapted from "Poor Communication May Be Slowing Down Your Team," on hbr.org, October 18, 2023.

9

What to Do When Your Team's Vibe Is Off

by Liane Davey

Is your team feeling stuck, stymied, or just a bit stale? Have you fallen into routines that are no longer serving you? It's OK; teams need occasional course corrections, even in calm waters. And in today's stormy seas, you might need to chart a whole new course as you navigate hybrid work arrangements. The good news is that resetting your team can be easier than you think.

Your first step is to reflect on what feels off. You can think about it in two broad categories. First, is the problem that your team has lost sight of your purpose and the goals you're working toward? If so, your reset will need to focus on realignment. The other possibility (and it could be both) is that you don't feel like a team anymore. Maybe team members feel disconnected, invalidated, or frustrated—so much so that even minor issues are causing conflict. In that case, your reset must focus on revitalizing your team dynamic.

Here's how to navigate both of these approaches.

Realignment

No matter your issue, it's good to begin with realignment. You'll want to prioritize realignment over revitalization for two reasons. First, many team dysfunctions manifest as trust issues when, in fact, they stem from discrepancies in goals, priorities, or expectations. Clearing up those misunderstandings often resolves what you thought were interpersonal issues.

Another reason to start with realignment is that it allows you to tie your reset to external shifts rather than individual behavior problems, making it less likely to trigger defensiveness. When you realign, you're not judging anyone; instead, you're asking how you need to evolve to capitalize on opportunities and mitigate emerging risks. Here are some anchor points for realignment. Choose the ones that best match your situation.

Reset your team's mandate

The first possibility is that your team's purpose needs to evolve. You can explore that possibility with these questions.

- *What external trends require you to adapt?* What are the most salient changes in the external environment, and how do they change the context for your team? For example, if you're a content marketing team, how does ChatGPT change your team's value?
- *How does a shift in company strategy affect your role?* Does your organization have a new vision, strategy, or KPI that alters what your team needs to deliver? For example, if you're an HR team, does opening European offices require new capabilities or activities?

- *How is your value within the organization evolving?* As organizations grow and change, the role of teams can evolve. How will changes in your organization structure require you to refocus? For example, how will you tailor your offerings if you're an R&D team now supporting two units instead of one?

Reset your team's goals

If your mandate has changed, you'll certainly need to revisit your goals, but even if your purpose is unchanged, your goals might need a refresh. So, consider these as reasons to move the target.

- *How will you build on prior results?* What did you accomplish in the last quarter, and how does that change the trajectory you want for the next few quarters? If you've been achieving your goals, are they ambitious enough? On the other hand, if you've been missing consistently, do you need to lower your goals or risk demoralizing everyone?
- *How will external factors affect your goals?* Is there anything external that might suggest a goal change? For example, do you need to temper expectations in light of an economic downturn, supply chain backlogs, or labor shortages? On the other hand, if your team benefits from new technological advances, could you accomplish more than planned?
- *What can you do to improve your measures?* Are your goals fuzzy, or are your metrics nebulous? Your fastest way to improve alignment might be to tighten your definitions or tweak your metrics, making it more evident whether you're getting traction.

Reset your strategies and tactics

Any changes based on your mandate or goals will necessitate reexamining your strategies. But don't limit a strategy refresh to situations where the targets have moved; considering new possibilities can be a good reset anytime.

- *Are your strategies aligned with your mandate?* If your mandate or goals have shifted, how must your strategy change in response? For example, if your team has been tasked with adding professional services to your software offering, what will it take to make that business model successful?
- *Where do you need revised tactics?* If you're still working toward existing goals, what's been working, and where could you change your tack? Conversely, what do you need to abandon? Where could you double down?
- *What contingencies might emerge?* Even if you're sticking with your existing mandate, goals, strategies, and tactics, you can reset by considering new scenarios and preparing your contingency plans. What assumptions are embedded in your current plan? What would negate those assumptions? What would be the leading indicators that something is changing?

Reset your roles

It's possible that your team is on the right track, but you're not optimizing the energy and talents of team members. In that case, consider these questions about individuals' accountabilities.

- *Do people need a change in role?* Are there any changes in roles or responsibilities that would make the people on your team more effective? Do you need to change someone's portfolio? Could you shake up who's in what role for multiskilling, development, or succession advantages? Who might be reinvigorated by a new challenge?

- *How could you make accountabilities more straightforward?* Are there opportunities to fine-tune people's responsibilities to make them more compelling? Are there spots where shared accountabilities are diluting people's sense of obligation? How could you increase alignment, efficiency, and effectiveness by clarifying who owns which decisions?

One of the most constructive ways to reset your team is to refocus on what your organization, colleagues, and customers are counting on you to do. Rekindling your team's passion and reminding them what you're fighting for is the best place to start.

Revitalization

The second type of reset is to revitalize your team dynamic. Does it feel like you've devolved from being a true team into a loose collection of people where the whole is no more than the sum of the parts? Or worse, is mistrust or unhealthy conflict making it feel like teamwork is a net negative? In that case, your reset might need to focus less on *what* your team needs to do and more on *how* you do it.

Reset your communication habits

Over time, teams can become lazy and fall into communication patterns that dilute connection. Revisiting your communication habits can help you reconnect.

- *Can you reset your communication channels?* Do you default to certain modes of communication that aren't optimized for the content? For example, if you're using Zoom to inform and email to debate, you've got it backward. Can you use richer communication vehicles for more novel content, contentious discussions, and unfamiliar participants? Can you shunt informational items to email?
- *How could you implement blackout periods?* In addition to the deluge of meetings, most people are also inundated by a torrent of emails. How could your team enforce blackout periods when people can turn off notifications and work without communication obligations? How can you increase the opportunities for people to work without distractions?

Reset your team dynamics

There may be times when interpersonal issues and conflict may be hiding under the surface. In this case, you need to take a closer look at team dynamics.

- *What would be your new ground rules?* Maybe you've had ground rules and stopped respecting them, or you never had any. What behaviors have you been tolerating that need to stop? What would be a welcome addition? Revisiting the principles for how team members behave can be an excellent way to reset.
- *How could you resolve conflict debts?* If your team has been avoiding difficult conversations about priorities and trade-offs or trust and disrespect, you need to get the issues out in the open to move beyond them.
- *What activities would foster insight into each other?* If your team dynamics are suffering, you might want to enlist outside help with formal team development activities. For example, psychometric tools or group coaching could foster trust and promote candor.

If your team is accomplishing plenty but finding it's harder than necessary, these different approaches will jump-start a new, healthier, happier team dynamic.

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As you ponder your team reset, consider whether you need to reset your own approach. For example, has work started consuming more time and energy than is healthy? Are you taking on too much and delegating too little? This is also the perfect opportunity to consider what reset you need as the team's leader.

QUICK RECAP

Is your team feeling stuck, stymied, or a bit stale? Resetting your team can be easier than you think.

- Has your team lost sight of your purpose and goals? Focus on realignment. If your team is feeling disconnected, invalidated, or frustrated, look to revitalization.
 - Realignment should be your first priority. It entails clearing up misunderstandings around your team's purpose, goals, strategies, and roles.
 - Revitalization is less about *what* your team needs to do and more about *how* you do it. Focus on updating your communication habits and your team's interpersonal dynamics.
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Adapted from “20 Questions to Ask When Your Team’s Vibe Is Off,” on hbr.org, July 19, 2023 (product #H07PT2).

Disagreement on your team? Read this article to learn how to handle it:

